

COMPLIANCE RESOURCE · 2026 EDITION

The Nilotica Shea EUDR *Playbook*

A practical guide for cosmetics, pharmaceutical, and food-grade buyers importing Vitellaria nilotica seed butter into the EU. Supplier templates, DDS checklists, risk frameworks, and a full compliance stress test — inside.

- SUPPLIER ENGAGEMENT TEMPLATES
- RISK ASSESSMENT FRAMEWORK
- DDS CHECKLIST
- COMPLIANCE STRESS TEST
- DECEMBER 30, 2026 DEADLINE

THE REGULATION

What the EUDR Requires — And Why It Matters for Shea

The EU Deforestation Regulation (EUDR) takes full effect on December 30, 2026. From that date, every shipment of a covered commodity entering the EU market must be backed by a verified Due Diligence Statement (DDS) registered in the EU TRACES system. The seven covered commodities are cattle, cocoa, coffee, palm oil, rubber, soy, and wood. Shea butter is not currently listed in Annex I and is not legally required to comply.

So why does this playbook exist? Because the cosmetics manufacturers, pharmaceutical ingredient buyers, and food companies who purchase *Vitellaria nilotica* seed butter are in scope — for palm oil, cocoa butter, and other covered ingredients across their supply chains. Under a regulation with fines starting at 4% of annual EU revenue, those buyers are moving toward suppliers who make traceability easy across every ingredient, in scope or not. EUDR pre-compliance is a commercial advantage, not a legal obligation — and that distinction is worth understanding clearly.

The regulation requires proof that your raw material did not come from land that was deforested or forest-degraded after January 1, 2020. That proof is not a declaration. It is documented, geo-referenced, cross-verified evidence — and it must be ready before the shipment moves.

Non-compliance consequences for covered commodity buyers: blocked shipments at the EU border, fines starting at 4% of annual EU revenue with seizure of goods and profits on top, and public listing as a non-compliant operator. There is no grace period after December 30, 2026.

WHO THIS APPLIES TO

The regulation covers three categories of actor. First, producers and importers who place covered commodities on the EU market for the first time. They carry the full due diligence obligation. Second, downstream operators who purchase, manufacture, or trade within the EU — they must retain and forward DDSs upon request. Third, small and micro primary operators from low-risk countries, who may qualify for simplified due diligence.

As an exporter of *Vitellaria nilotica* seed butter to EU buyers, Atunile Organics supports its importers with complete pre-compliance documentation. Our EU buyer partners are the ones submitting the DDS in TRACES — but the quality of what they can submit depends entirely on the data trail we provide from the harvest side.

What "pre-compliant" means at Atunile Organics: our geospatial harvest zone documentation is built on Google Earth Engine and Global Forest Watch satellite data. Our cooperative registry is active. Our EUDR traceability framework is in place and available to qualified EU importers on request. We are not scrambling to build this in Q4 2026.

WHAT GOES INTO A DUE DILIGENCE STATEMENT

Each DDS must contain geo-referenced plot coordinates for the harvest origin, verified legality documentation, a risk assessment mapped to Article 10 thresholds, and supporting evidence justifying a low-risk or negligible-risk conclusion. The DDS is then uploaded to EU TRACES, where it receives a reference number that travels with the shipment.

Missing any one of these components means the DDS is incomplete. An incomplete DDS does not pass the border. This is the most common failure point for shea importers who treat GPS coordinates as sufficient. They are not. Auditors assess the depth and completeness of your risk documentation, not just the presence of a map pin.

STEP ONE

Supplier Engagement Templates

Your EUDR compliance is only as strong as the data your suppliers can provide. This section gives you the engagement framework and

communication templates to collect what you need, in a format that works for smallholder cooperative contexts — which is exactly the supply chain environment *Vitellaria nilotica* comes from.

WHAT YOU NEED FROM YOUR SUPPLIER

DATA POINT	FORMAT REQUIRED	ATUNILE STATUS
Harvest plot geolocation	GPS coordinates (polygon or centroid), KML or GeoJSON	DOCUMENTED
Plot size and boundaries	Hectares, with satellite overlay confirmation	DOCUMENTED
Land use rights / title	Community land agreement or government permit	ON FILE
Deforestation cross-check	GFW or equivalent satellite verification post-2020	COMPLETED
Cooperative registration	Government-issued registration number	ACTIVE
Harvest season records	Volume by season, per cooperative	TRACKED
Processing facility certification	UNBS or equivalent	UNBS CERTIFIED

SUPPLIER ENGAGEMENT EMAIL TEMPLATE

Use this template to initiate data collection from a new cooperative or processing partner. Adapt the cooperative name and harvest zone references to your specific supplier context.

TEMPLATE: INITIAL EUDR DATA REQUEST TO SUPPLIER

Subject: EU Deforestation Regulation — Data Request for [Cooperative Name]

Dear [Contact Name],

We are writing regarding the EU Deforestation Regulation (EUDR), which takes effect December 30, 2026. While shea butter is not yet listed in EUDR's mandatory scope, our EU buyers operate under full EUDR compliance obligations for their wider ingredient portfolios. As a result, we are proactively building complete supply chain traceability across all our sourcing — including *Vitellaria nilotica* — to ensure our buyers can work with us without friction, now and if the regulation's scope expands.

To continue our trading relationship and support your access to EU buyers, we need the following documentation from your cooperative. We have designed this process to be straightforward and we will walk you through each step.

- GPS coordinates for each harvest zone (polygon boundaries preferred)
- Cooperative registration certificate
- Land use documentation or community agreement for each harvest area
- Estimated annual harvest volume by zone (last two seasons)

Please send your documents to [email] by [date]. If you have questions about what format is needed or how to collect GPS data, contact us and we will support you directly. This documentation protects your market access and we want to make it as easy as possible to complete.

Thank you for your continued partnership.

THE NILOTICA ADVANTAGE IN SUPPLIER ENGAGEMENT

Wild-harvested *Vitellaria nilotica* from the Nile Basin parklands presents a fundamentally lower deforestation risk than plantation-grown or agriculturally expanded shea supply chains. The trees are protected under Ugandan national law. The harvest zones have not changed in generations. This makes supplier engagement faster and the resulting documentation stronger — a structural advantage over West African supply chains that EU buyers will increasingly recognise.

Risk Assessment Framework

Risk assessments are the most common failure point in EUDR compliance. The regulation does not ask you to confirm a location exists. It asks you to prove that location is deforestation-free and legally harvested. That requires cross-referencing your GPS data against verified global datasets, scoring legality indicators, and documenting your findings against Article 10 thresholds.

Common mistake: submitting geolocations without running a deforestation cross-check. Auditors look for evidence of process, not just coordinates. If you cannot show how you assessed the risk, the assessment fails.

THE SEVEN RISK CATEGORIES (ARTICLE 10)

- 1

DEFORESTATION AND FOREST DEGRADATION
Cross-reference harvest polygons against Global Forest Watch (GFW) Hansen data and PRODES alerts. The threshold is any deforestation event after December 31, 2020. Use satellite imagery from two reference points minimum.
- 2

COUNTRY AND AREA RISK
Assess the source country's governance stability, corruption index, environmental enforcement capacity, and forest monitoring infrastructure. Uganda's national parkland tree protection laws are a positive legality indicator.
- 3

LEGALITY OF HARVEST RIGHTS
Document land use rights, community agreements, and harvesting permits. For wild-harvest cooperatives, community land use agreements and local government recognition of the cooperative constitute adequate legality evidence.
- 4

INDIGENOUS AND LOCAL COMMUNITY RIGHTS
Confirm that harvest activities comply with the rights of indigenous and local communities. Women-led cooperative structures with documented income distribution are strong indicators of community alignment.
- 5

THIRD PARTY RIGHTS
Verify no third party land rights conflict with harvest boundaries. For parkland zones this requires cross-checking against national land registry records and any known dispute history.
- 6

SANCTIONS AND TRADE RESTRICTIONS
Confirm the country is not under EU, UN, or bilateral sanctions relevant to the commodity. Uganda is not sanctioned. Verify annually — sanctions status can change.
- 7

MIXED SOURCING AND BUNDLING
If shea from multiple origins is blended, the highest-risk origin governs the assessment. Atunile Organics maintains single-origin traceability per batch — each batch references one cooperative and one harvest zone.

RISK SCORING REFERENCE

RISK LEVEL	MEANING	ACTION REQUIRED
Negligible	No indicators of deforestation or legal non-compliance found across all datasets	Document findings, proceed to DDS
Low	Minor gaps in documentation; no evidence of deforestation	Request additional supplier docs, document mitigation
Standard	Unresolved indicators that require active investigation	Open mitigation workflow, do not proceed to DDS until resolved
High	Confirmed deforestation indicator or legal non-compliance	Disqualify this harvest batch from EU-bound shipment

DDS Checklist — What Must Be Ready Before Every Shipment

Use this checklist for every EU-bound shipment of Vitellaria nilotica seed butter. Nothing moves until every box is checked. The DDS is only as solid as the documentation behind it.

PHASE 1: ORIGIN DOCUMENTATION

☐ GEOLOCATION

GPS polygon coordinates for each harvest zone in this batch. Accepted formats: KML, GeoJSON, or decimal degree coordinates. Minimum accuracy: 10 metres.

☐ PLOT SIZE

Hectare area for each polygon. Cross-check that stated area matches satellite-derived measurement within 10%.

☐ COOPERATIVE REGISTRY

Cooperative name, registration number, and confirmation that the harvest zone falls within documented cooperative territory.

☐ HARVEST SEASON AND VOLUME

Confirmed harvest date range and total volume (kg) attributable to this harvest zone for this shipment batch.

PHASE 2: DEFORESTATION VERIFICATION

☐ GFW CROSS-CHECK

Global Forest Watch deforestation alert query run for each polygon. Screenshot or export saved with batch reference. Date of check recorded.

☐ SATELLITE IMAGERY

Reference satellite image saved for the harvest polygon from at least two dates: one before January 1, 2020 and one within the last 12 months. Shows no change in forest cover.

☐ RISK SCORE

Article 10 risk assessment completed. Score documented as Negligible or Low. If Standard or above, mitigation workflow must be completed before proceeding.

PHASE 3: LEGALITY AND PROCESSING

☐ LAND USE DOCUMENTATION

Community land agreement, government permit, or recognised cooperative harvest rights documentation. Dated and signed by authorised party.

☐ PROCESSING CERTIFICATE

UNBS processing facility certificate current and on file. Certificate reference number matches processing facility used for this batch.

☐ CERTIFICATE OF ANALYSIS

Batch COA issued, signed, and matching product specification sheet. Acid value, oleic acid profile, and moisture content within spec.

PHASE 4: DDS SUBMISSION

☐ EU TRACES ACCOUNT ACTIVE

Importer's EU TRACES account confirmed active. If using a third-party system, integration confirmed live and tested with a dummy DDS.

☐ DDS DRAFTED AND REVIEWED

All required fields populated: operator details, commodity HS code, geolocation reference, risk assessment conclusion, supporting documentation list.

☐ DDS SUBMITTED AND REFERENCE NUMBER OBTAINED

DDS submitted in EU TRACES. Reference number saved and attached to shipment documentation. This number must accompany the physical goods.

☐ FIVE-YEAR AUDIT FILE CREATED

Complete documentation package archived in your EUDR audit folder: DDS, COA, geolocation files, risk assessment export, satellite imagery, legality documents. Retained for minimum five years.

Timeline and Compliance Stress Test

This final section gives you a planning timeline and a self-assessment stress test. Use the timeline to confirm your implementation schedule is realistic. Use the stress test to identify the gaps in your current approach before an auditor does.

SIX-MONTH COUNTDOWN TO DECEMBER 30, 2026

JUL 2026	AUG 2026	SEP 2026	OCT 2026	NOV 2026	DEC 30, 2026
Scope and data inventory	Due diligence framework live	Supplier data collected	Risk assessments run	Mitigation closed	DDS live. No exceptions.

The single most common timeline mistake: underestimating supplier data collection. Allow two to three months minimum. Cooperative structures in Uganda work on relationship timelines, not corporate timelines. Begin engagement now.

COMPLIANCE STRESS TEST — SIX QUESTIONS TO ASK YOUR SYSTEM

Run through these questions against your current EUDR setup. Honest answers reveal where your compliance is solid and where it needs work before the deadline.

QUESTION 1

Can you retrieve the complete documentation trail for any single shipment within 24 hours of an audit request?

If the answer is no, your audit readiness is a risk. Competent authorities can issue unscheduled audits at any time. A digital audit folder, maintained per batch, is the minimum requirement. Spreadsheets are not sufficient at scale.

QUESTION 2

Does your risk assessment actually check for deforestation, or does it just confirm coordinates exist?

Submitting GPS coordinates without a GFW or equivalent deforestation cross-check does not constitute a compliant risk assessment under Article 10. Valid geolocations are a starting point, not a conclusion.

QUESTION 3

If a risk assessment comes back failing, do you have a mitigation workflow that does not halt the entire supply chain?

Mitigation processes need to be designed before you need them. Know which risks can be resolved with additional supplier documentation, and which are disqualifiers that remove the batch from EU eligibility entirely.

QUESTION 4

Is your EU TRACES integration tested at full shipment volume, or only in a demo environment?

An untested integration is a compliance risk. Test it under real conditions — actual DDS data, real geolocation files, production-level volume. Manual TRACES entry does not scale.

QUESTION 5

Does your supplier engagement process cover tier-two suppliers, or only your direct contacts?

If your direct cooperative sources from additional sub-cooperatives or individual harvesters, those upstream origins also fall within your due diligence scope. Traceability must extend to where the nut was picked, not just where the butter was processed.

QUESTION 6

Is your five-year audit archive structured so a third party could navigate it without your guidance?

Auditors do not want to be walked through your folder structure. Build the archive so that any qualified reviewer can find the DDS, the risk assessment, the geolocation files, and the legality documents for any batch by batch reference number alone.

Ready to Source EUDR-Ready Nilotica?

Atunile Organics supplies Vitellaria nilotica seed butter with EUDR pre-compliance documentation available to qualified EU importers on request. Wild-harvested. Nile Basin origin. UNBS certified. Organic certification in progress.

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VITELLARIA NILOTICA SEED BUTTER · NORTHERN UGANDA · NILE BASIN
PARKLANDS · EUDR PRE-COMPLIANT · UNBS CERTIFIED